strongest contrast to all this . . . Our coats and trousers were torn and dirty, our lips and faces blistered by the sun.'[7]

As Pollock's force streamed into the city, they were pointedly piped in to the strains of the old Jacobite air, 'Oh, But Ye've Been Lang a'Coming'.

General Pollock, as ever, was not to be rushed. His progress was as methodical, and as ruthlessly violent, as ever.

While he was consolidating his hold on the Khyber, Pollock's sepoys had begun the process of taking revenge for earlier Afghan atrocities by decapitating the dead Afridis they had killed and carrying 'the heads into camp in triumph, stuck on the points of their bayonets'. There were also a number of Afridi women among the dead.[kk] When one of Pollock's officers, Lieutenant Greenwood, remonstrated with the sepoys responsible, one of them replied simply, 'Sahib I have lost twelve brethren in this accursed pass, and I would happily bayonet a Kyberee a month old at his mother's breast.'[8]

Pollock showed little sign of wishing to restrain such tendencies and, as his force headed on towards Jalalabad, villages deemed hostile were torched as the Army of Retribution passed by. In one hamlet, where some plundered British property and the uniforms of some murdered soldiers had been discovered, the entire village was methodically reduced to rubble. 'The destruction of Ali Boghan', explained Pollock nonchalantly in his next despatch, 'was caused by one of those sudden bursts of feeling against which, being wholly unexpected, no precautions were considered necessary.'[9]

On arrival at Jalalabad, Pollock paused again. While there were many in the garrison who wished him to pursue the fleeing Akbar Khan to Kabul without delay, Pollock was determined to leave nothing to chance. He felt that since the garrison had already eaten all their camels he did not have enough baggage animals to carry adequate supplies forward; in his view at least 9,000 new camels needed to be found before he could move forward to retake Kabul.[10]

Moreover, it was still unclear how far the new Governor General would authorise him to proceed, and there were increasing signs that the once hawkish Ellenborough was getting cold feet. Anxious about the empty treasury in Calcutta, Ellenborough began sending messages to Pollock and